CSIS AUSTRALIA CHAIR

Australia Daily Brief

Wednesday, October 21, 2026

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RE: Haines loses both legs, driver in court · Israel joins Pacific Islands Forum as partner · RBA's Hauser warns inflation 'materially worse' · Austal wins record $245m defence loan · PNG parliament debates Bougainville timetable

ASX 200	AUD/USD	NZX 50	NZD/USD
8,831	0.7028	13,761	0.5689
+1.18%	+0.72%	+0.01%	+1.41%

IN THIS ISSUE Top Stories · Overnight · Stat · Pacific · New Zealand · Canberra · Markets · Upcoming · The Wire · Analysis

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. Israel's acceptance as a Pacific Islands Forum partner drew immediate criticism in Wellington, with New Zealand Labour saying Christopher Luxon has 'serious questions to answer.'
2. RBA Deputy Governor Andrew Hauser's warning that inflation has turned 'materially worse' pushed market pricing toward a rate rise at the bank's next decision, reversing recent expectations of a hold.
3. PNG's parliament reopened debate on a Bougainville independence timetable, with any move requiring a three-quarters majority against the 2019 referendum's 97.9 percent vote for independence.

TOP STORIES

AU-POLITICS

Haines loses both legs as accused driver appears in court

Helen Haines, independent MP for Indi, has lost both legs after being struck by a vehicle outside her Wangaratta electorate office on Monday. **Brendan Nugent**, 43, faces three charges, including the federal offence of causing harm to a Commonwealth public official; his lawyer told Wangaratta Magistrates' Court he suffers a rare neurological condition. No bail application was made and Nugent returns to court in February.

per Reuters: "Australian lawmaker loses both legs in vehicle attack as suspect appears in court" · also AP, Washington Post, New York Times

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Israel joins Pacific Islands Forum as development partner

Israel has been accepted as a partner of the Pacific Islands Forum, the Israeli Foreign Ministry announced Wednesday, with the decision taken at last month's leaders meeting in Palau. As a partner, Israel joins the Forum's Sectoral Partnership Stream, focused on water management, desalination, agriculture, and climate adaptation; the PIF now counts more than two dozen external dialogue partners, including the United States, China, the United Kingdom, France, and the European Union.

per RNZ Pacific: "Israel joins Pacific Islands Forum as partner" · also Reuters, AFP

AU-DEFENSE

Labor issues record $245 million loan to shipbuilder Austal

The Albanese government has granted shipbuilder **Austal** a *$245 million* loan for a Perth defence project, the single largest investment so far under the government's $15 billion National Reconstruction Fund. The financing underscores Canberra's push to expand sovereign shipbuilding capacity as naval industrial demand grows.

per AFR: "Labor's huge loan to ship builder Austal for Perth defence project"

OVERNIGHT

AU-POLITICS

Prosecutors reconsider plea deal in MP harassment case · ABC News

Prosecutors are reconsidering a plea offer put to a man accused of sending multiple menacing emails to a South Australian federal MP, a court has heard, citing recent events. The reconsideration follows this week's attack on independent MP **Helen Haines** and heightened scrutiny of threats against parliamentarians.

AU-POLITICS

Wilson says Liberals must become a 'big target' on policy · Politico Canberra Playbook

Shadow Treasurer **Tim Wilson** said the Liberal Party needs to become a 'big target' with bold policy positions to win back inner-city seats, Politico reports. His comments come as the Opposition under **Angus Taylor** weighs its electoral strategy.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Australia seeks global alliance against Big Tech child harms · Bloomberg

Australia is seeking to build an international coalition of governments to press major technology platforms on harms to children, Bloomberg reports, extending Canberra's push following its world-first social media age restrictions. Details of prospective partner countries were not specified.

TRADE-ECONOMY

CSL names GSK executive Deborah Waterhouse as next CEO · Reuters

Australia's **CSL** has named GSK executive **Deborah Waterhouse** as its next chief executive, Reuters reports. The appointment comes as the biotech group navigates a competitive global vaccines and plasma market.

TRADE-ECONOMY

NextDC shares tumble on revenue delay, expansion plans shelved · Reuters

Shares in Australian data centre operator **NextDC** tumbled after a revenue delay and the shelving of expansion plans, with Reuters reporting a *42 percent* slide and the Financial Times putting the fall at 44 percent. The sell-off adds to pressure on Australia's data centre sector amid power supply constraints.

STAT OF THE DAY

$245 million

Record National Reconstruction Fund loan to Austal

The loan is the largest single investment to date under Labor's $15 billion National Reconstruction Fund, financing a Perth defence shipbuilding project.

AFR

PACIFIC WIRE

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ABC PACIFIC

PNG parliament resumes debate on Bougainville independence timetable

PNG's national parliament restarted debate on a timetable for Bougainville independence, following the 2019 referendum in which *97.9 percent* of voters backed independence. Bougainville Affairs Minister **Manasseh Makiba** said PNG law requires a three-quarters parliamentary majority before independence can proceed; Abau MP **Sir Puka Temu** voiced strong support.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ABC PACIFIC

PNG university students to gain access to ADF enlistment

Papua New Guinean university students will be able to apply to join the Australian Defence Force from next month, expanding a defence partnership between Canberra and Port Moresby. The change follows broader cooperation announcements covering health, security, and digital initiatives between the two countries.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ISLANDS BUSINESS

PNG and Australia announce new health, security and digital initiatives

Papua New Guinea and Australia unveiled new cooperation initiatives spanning health, security, and digital infrastructure, per Islands Business's PACNEWS bulletin, deepening a bilateral alliance that already includes defence force recruitment and labour mobility programs.

SOLOMON ISLANDS · RNZ PACIFIC

Solomon Islands PM pushes for two-thirds boost to PALM scheme

Prime Minister **Matthew Wale** called for the number of Solomon Islanders working in Australia under the Pacific Australia Labour Mobility scheme to rise to *5,000* a year, up from the current 4,000, telling an employer expo in Honiara that more than 13,000 Solomon Islanders have participated since 2018.

MICRONESIA (FSM) · PACIFIC ISLAND TIMES

FSM opens Skills Certification Unit under World Bank program

The Federated States of Micronesia opened a new Skills Certification Unit at the College of Micronesia in Pohnpei on October 14, part of a World Bank funded program to revitalise vocational education. President **Wesley Simina** led the opening, aimed at building a skilled workforce and job opportunities for young Micronesians.

AMERICAN SAMOA · RNZ PACIFIC

Environmental groups and chiefs sue over American Samoa seabed mining plans

An environmental group has filed suit challenging US legal authority to sell seabed mining leases covering more than *31 million acres* off American Samoa, as the Trump administration pushes toward a sale scheduled for November 19. It would mark the first time the United States has offered such leases, despite opposition from local residents and environmental groups.

COOK ISLANDS · RNZ PACIFIC

Stranded traveller caught between Cook Islands, NZ and Australia visa rules

A 49-year-old foreign national stuck in Rarotonga says she will accept detention if it proves she intends only to return home, after Australia and New Zealand both declined to confirm a transit visa. Cook Islands Immigration says it cannot resolve her overstayer status without action from either country.

FIJI · ABC PACIFIC

Fiji debates whether Christianity should be a founding constitutional value

Ahead of a proposed constitutional referendum, Fiji's National Federation Party opposes declaring the country a Christian state but supports recognising Christianity alongside other faiths in the preamble, assistant general secretary **Apenisa Vatuniveivuke** said. The debate touches on religious diversity and protections for minority faith communities.

NEW ZEALAND

NZ-FOREIGN-POLICY · RNZ PACIFIC

Labour says Luxon has 'serious questions to answer' on Israel PIF move

New Zealand Labour's foreign affairs spokesperson said Prime Minister **Christopher Luxon** has 'serious questions to answer' after Israel joined the Pacific Islands Forum as a development partner. Luxon called the partnership 'lower tier' and said the decision was ultimately the Forum's to make; ACT leader **David Seymour** welcomed Israel's entry.

NZ-POLITICS · REUTERS

Overseas New Zealanders can start voting from Wednesday

Overseas New Zealanders became eligible to begin casting ballots from Wednesday ahead of the country's November 7 general election. In-country advance voting opens October 26, under the National-ACT-NZ First coalition government led by **Christopher Luxon**.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · ABC POLITICS

Paterson calls for review of MP security after Haines attack

Shadow Minister for Defence **James Paterson** called for a review of security provided to federal parliamentarians following the attack on **Helen Haines**. The call adds to growing cross-party pressure for stronger protective measures for MPs.

AU-POLITICS · THE GUARDIAN

AFP warns of 'tsunami' of youth radicalisation accelerated by AI

Acting AFP Deputy Commissioner **Sandra Booth** told a parliamentary inquiry that children as young as 11 are being radicalised online within days rather than months, warning of a 'tsunami of youth crime.' Police are considering expanded powers to disrupt harmful online chat groups.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Taylor warned ratifying EU trade deal a 'serious mistake'

Opposition Leader **Angus Taylor** has been warned that ratifying the EU free trade agreement over net zero provisions would be a 'profoundly undemocratic' and 'serious mistake,' as the Coalition weighs its position on the pact.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

AFP data shows threats to MPs up fourfold since 2020

AFP Commissioner **Krissy Barrett** said authorities are charging almost one individual every week for targeting Commonwealth parliamentarians, with threats against federal politicians up fourfold since 2020. The data underscores a deteriorating security environment following the attack on Helen Haines.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Victorian premier convenes cabinet on MP security after Haines attack

Victorian Premier **Ben Carroll** called a special cabinet meeting to discuss safety arrangements for elected members after the attack on federal MP Helen Haines. More than a dozen Victorian politicians have reported threats against themselves, their families, or campaign volunteers ahead of the state's November 28 election.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · AFR

Rate rise bets jump after RBA warns of 'materially worse' inflation

Economists say the Reserve Bank is increasingly prepared to risk a recession as inflation worsens beyond its forecasts, even as the labour market softens. Deputy Governor **Andrew Hauser** called the inflation outlook 'materially worse,' with markets now pricing *just over a 40 percent chance* of a rate rise at the bank's next decision, on Melbourne Cup Day.

TRADE-ECONOMY · POLITICO CANBERRA PLAYBOOK

EU to Australia: 'Once negotiations are done, they're done'

The EU's trade side pushed back on Australian efforts to reopen terms of the EU-Australia free trade deal, with an EU official telling Politico 'once negotiations are done, they're done.' The exchange, involving **Tim Wilson** and EU official **Olof Gill**, comes as the Nationals withhold support for ratification.

TRADE-ECONOMY · BLOOMBERG

Ares warns of Australian private credit stress from rising rates

Global investment firm Ares warned of emerging stress in Australian private credit markets as interest rates climb, Bloomberg reports, flagging risk concentration among non-bank lenders exposed to commercial property and corporate loans.

UPCOMING

OCT 26 — **New Zealand advance voting opens**
Marks the start of in-country voting ahead of the November 7 general election.

NOV 7 — **New Zealand general election**
Decides whether the National-ACT-NZ First coalition under Christopher Luxon continues in government.

NOV 28

Victorian state election

First major state poll since the attack on federal MP Helen Haines, with campaign security arrangements under review.

NOV 2026

RBA's next cash rate decision, referenced as falling on Melbourne Cup Day

Markets are pricing just over a 40 percent chance of a hike after Deputy Governor Hauser's 'materially worse' inflation warning.

FEB 2027

Brendan Nugent's next court appearance in the Haines case

Will test charges including the federal offence of causing harm to a Commonwealth public official.

THE WIRE

AU-DEFENSE

ASPI STRATEGIST

ASPI: Canada's defence acquisition model offers lessons for Australia

Australia should examine Canada's new integrated defence acquisition and industry funding model to test whether its forthcoming Defence Delivery Agency has enough commercial freedom to deliver capability quickly, the ASPI Strategist argues.

ASPI STRATEGIST

ASPI: Australia is a regional maritime power and should act like one

As Australia rebuilds its aged naval fleet, it should also rebuild how it perceives itself as a longstanding regional maritime power, the ASPI Strategist argues, rather than treating naval capability as a recent addition to strategy.

TRADE-ECONOMY

DEVPOLICY BLOG

Devpolicy: Struggle, reform, boom, bust, then what for the PNG economy?

PNG's economy has rebounded from a 'quiet bust' decade, but with jobs growth still lagging behind output, Devpolicy's **Stephen Howes** and co-authors ask whether the recovery amounts to a genuine boom. The analysis draws on the ANU-UPNG Partnership research program.

ANALYSIS AND OPINION

THE DIPLOMAT

Bougainville Needs a Credible Timetable for PNG's Independence Vote. Australia Can Help.

The piece argues Australia should avoid taking a position on Bougainville's independence outcome itself, while using its influence to encourage Port Moresby to set a credible timetable for resolving the 2019 referendum result. It frames this as a way to reduce uncertainty without appearing to dictate PNG's sovereign choice.

Argument: Canberra should stay out of what Port Moresby decides on Bougainville but can push for a concrete timeline for the independence decision.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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